

The Grandfather Tree

Grandfather Tree¹

Within the heart of the High Forest, a gnarled oak tree of monstrous proportions towers above the surrounding trees. This is the much-fabled ancestor mound called Grandfather Tree, and it is considered holy ground to a number of northern barbarian tribes as well as most of the natives of the forest. Four lesser oak trees, dwarfed by the spread of Grandfather Tree's branches, mark the quarters around its base and act as monolithic boundary marks for the inner cairn and ancestor mound. Only a few rotted stumps and fallen logs remain of the Blue Bear tribe totems. The colossal oak tree and its guardian spirits project what is akin to a natural ward. It negates any detection or location magics trained on anyone within 100 yards of its branches, just as the tree itself is immune to location magics and scrying. It also prevents anyone from *teleporting* or *gating* within a mile of its central trunk; said magics can be used to move away from Grandfather Tree, but any attempts to *teleport* or magically move closer to the tree are negated. Allies of the Tree Ghost tribe, and especially worshipers of Mielikki, Silvanus, Eldath, or Rillifane Rallathil, heal at twice the normal amount (via spells or natural healing) when under the spread of Grandfather Tree's branches. Under Grandfather Tree are the Halls of Mist an ancient shrine and the giant ant tunnels that wind around the roots of Grandfather Tree.

The adventure begins when a strange man dressed in green approaches the adventurers and says "Beneath Grandfather Tree in the High Forest lies an ancient shrine with doors that open onto evil worlds. A force of evil has invaded the ancient temple and seeks to possess those gates and the secrets of the Race Creator Room. Prevent these doors from being used to further evil for me and the treasure that surrounds them are yours to keep." The strange man will not elaborate further upon what a "force of evil" is or what monsters the adventurers should expect to encounter. Should the adventurers accept his quest, he gives them a wish-bone-shaped branch from the ancient tree. If used like a divining rod, the branch always points towards Grandfather Tree.²

The entrance into the Halls of Mist is found 69' high in the fork of the main trunk. A simple hatch opens to reveal a dark, smooth wooden ladder dropping through the center of the hollow trunk. The ladder drops 85' to end in a small, dark; tree root lined room with earthen walls and floor.

1. Entrance Room.

The wooden ladder descends into a small 4' wide by 7' long room with a 5' high roof. A smaller passage runs to the right and has a roof 4' high. This passage ends in a badly tarnished bronze door set into a rusting iron frame with iron hinges. Two bronze crosspieces bar the door shut. To the left, is a gentle down-sloping passage that leads to a smaller, but slightly wider room. That passage continues from the room and descends farther into the ground.

The air is dry and warm and there are several tracks in the earthen floor. They are all jumbled together and make identification impossible.

2. Bear With Me

In this 10' wide room there appears to be nothing of interest but a large, stone grizzly bear statue set into an alcove in the wall. The bear rests on its haunches over a large bone-handled dagger resting on a rotting wooden pedestal. Gold and the shine of gems reflect from the dagger.

The bone handle of the dagger is carved in the likeness of a great male lion. The eyes are small red rubies. Picking the dagger will cause nothing to happen. Further inspection of the statue will reveal that it is designed to pivot on its base.

Turning the bear statue to right will cause 16 stone-tipped spears to drop from the roof. All characters are required to roll a save versus paralyzation to take half damage from this trap. Damage is 1d6x16. Turning the statue to the left will cause a secret panel in the side of the pedestal to open revealing a rusty ironbound chest. The chest is locked and trapped with a *symbol of blindness*. A successful save versus magic will negate the effects of the *symbol*. Within the chest is a pair of bearskin leather gloves tipped with bear claws and a necklace made of bear claws and teeth. Both items are sacred to the Blue Bear tribe. Taking the items from the chest will cause the bear to animate and attack the PC carrying the items.

Bear statue: INT 3; AL N; AC 4; MV 9; HD 6; hp 48; THACO 14; #AT 3; Dmg 1d6/1d6/1d8; SA on a roll of 20, hugs for 2d8. When reduced to 0 hp, the bear will *teleport* to its perch to heal for 5 rounds and then will resume its hunt for the items.

The dagger is a *Lion's Bane* +3/+4³ a unique magical dagger.

3. The Bathtub.

This large room is 18' wide and 24' long and has a 6' high roof that gently arches over a large wooden tub set in the center of this room. The tub is half-filled with fresh water. Four benches of intricately carved oak sit in the water. On a rotting wooden shelf rests four intricately carved wooden spoons carved with the images of bears and eagles. Under the shelf is a moldy pile of rotting cloth.

Beside the tub is rotting wooden box that can be easily ripped open. Inside the box is a small tarnished

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silver plate mirror (worth 10 gp). Under the mirror is a scraper made from the shoulder blade of a large bear carved with intricate carvings of bears, treants, and eagles. Beside the scraper is a deer antler rattle. In the bottom of the box is a damp, loose pile of red clay, ground pumice, adobe, and colored dolomite (red, yellow, green). Buried under the clay is a large bone-handled obsidian knife with a large uncut ruby in the pommel (worth 400 gp).

The rattle and scraper are sacred to the Blue Bear Tribe barbarians. A gentle downward sloping passage crisscrossed with roots leads from this room with a 5' high roof.

4. Painting on the Wall.

This large room is 18' wide and 24' long and all four walls have crude paintings upon them done in natural paints. The domed roof is unpainted and is laced with roots from the trees above. The paintings are of bears hunting, trees walking, and men slaying fearsome monsters.

5. The Chimney Room.

This large 8' oblong room has a slightly raised center with a small firepit in the center and a narrow chimney leading to the outside. The chimney is too small even for a halfling to crawl through.

Depending upon the time of day that the adventurers reach this point, dim sunlight may filter in through the chimney. The firepit is still warm and shows recent use. The tracks in the dirt floor are terribly jumbled and make identification nearly impossible.

6. The Door.

This large oaken ironbound door has been ripped from its frame and rests on the floor. There must have been some form of magical protection upon the door, as there are several dead orcs, around the door.

7. Meeting Hall.

This room is the largest that you have seen yet, being 24' wide and 12' long. The ceiling is domed, latticed with tree benches, and reaches 12' at its peak. In the center of the roof is a large chimney opening. Under the chimney is a large firepit that still smolders. On the opposite side of the room is a large stone basin around which are grouped a small band of six goblins and two worgs.

Goblin (6): INT 5; AL LE; AC 6; MV 6; HD 1-1; hp 3; THACO 20; #AT 1; Dmg 1d6; MR nil; SZ S; ML 10.

Worgs (2): INT 5; AL NE; AC 6; MV 18; HD 3+3; hp 33; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; MR nil; SZ M; ML 11.

The basin is half filled with fresh water in which several leaves float. On the bottom of the basin is a large obsidian ladle shaped like a giant bear that shows no tool marks (magically formed). The face of the bear is carved into the back of the spoon with two fire topazes set in the eyes. The ladle is sacred to Blue Bear tribe and is worth 500 gp.

8. Ants.

This room has a 4' ceiling and is 18' wide and 12' long. The room appears to have been the scene of a major battle. The floor is littered with bits of leather and dotted with large patches of blood and a few mostly stripped skeletons of orcs, goblins, and a couple of worgs. Giant black ants are crawling all over the room and are carrying bits of leather and flesh back to their tunnels.

Disturbing the ants will cause them to attack immediately. Walking carefully through the room will not alarm the ants.

Giant ants, workers (40): INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 3; hp 24; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; MR nil; SZ S; ML 9.

9. More Ants.

This wide, expanding room is 30' long and 20' wide and has a 4' high ceiling. The floor is again dotted with the debris of a battle. There are several ants scurrying over this debris.

Giant ants, workers (20): INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 3; hp 24; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; MR nil; SZ S; ML 9.

Giant ants, warriors (10): INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 5; hp 40; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; SA sting for 3d4, a successful save versus poison reduces damage to 1d4, *phase*; MR nil; SZ M; ML 12.

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10. Dirt Room.

The acrid smell of smoke hangs in this large room. The room has two passages leaving it on the left and right. Grouped around two smoldering fires is a sorry looking bunch of gnolls. They appear beat up and are trying to rest and patch up their wounds.

Gnoll (37): INT 5; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 2; hp 16; THACO 19; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; SZ L; ML 11.

Gnoll Leaders (3): INT 5; AL CE; AC 4; MV 9; HD 3; hp 24; THACO 18; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; SZ L; ML 11.

Gnoll Subchief: INT 5; AL CE; AC 3; MV 9; HD 4; hp 32; THACO 16; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4+3; SZ L; ML 11; *Twyla's bag of holding*⁴, 250 lb.

The gnolls are part of Tantra Hagra's troops and will fight until 1/3 of their number has been reduced and then will try to retreat into the depths of the halls or parlay with the PCs. They carry 3 sp, 4 gp, 4 diamonds (30 gp each).

11A. Small Alcove.

This small area has a small wooden statue of a bear with several smashed clay bowls with rotting bits of leather scattered about. The bear shows recent damage from edged weapons and one of the ears has been broken off.

Lifting the statue will reveal a secret compartment that contains a bone handled dagger in a rotting leather sheath lying on top of a small, locked chest. The chest is untrapped and opening it will reveal a large white tome. The covers of the tome are covered in white elk hide stretched over finger thick boards of black oak. Each cover bears a curious rune of four arrows meeting in a circle.

The tome is the *Tome of the Covenant*⁵. The dagger has a slim narrow blade that is coated in oil and bears faint scrollwork down both sides. The dagger is a *jump dagger*⁶ and will require a new sheath.

11B. Potted Priests.

This long, low roofed (2.5' tall) tunnel leads back about 20' then forks into two tunnels.

The right passage ends in a dead end, but the left winds down to dead-end in a narrow room 10' wide by 6' wide with a 5' high roof. In the center of this room are six large clay pots about 7' tall.

Smashing open the pots will reveal that each holds a dried corpse of an elderly human male. This destruction will release a guardian spirit that will immediately attack the offending character.

Guardian Spirit: INT 9; AL CN; AC 3; MV 12; HD 8; hp 64; THACO 12; #AT 1; Dmg nil; SA *age* 10-40 years (1d4), *magic jar* one individual per day; SD hit by silver or magical weapons of +2 or better, can not be turned because on holy ground.

Within the pots are 300 gp of various gems and precious stones.

11C. Ants Again.

Crawling down this long dirt tunnel will reveal nothing of interest. Should the adventurers persist in crawling down this tunnel, they encounter 15 giant worker ants dragging the remains of a mule.

Giant ants, workers (40): INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 3; hp 24; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; MR nil; SZ S; ML 9.

Giant ants, workers (10): INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 5; hp 40; #AT 1; Dmg 3d4; SA *phase*; MR nil; SZ M; ML 9.

11D. Trapped Tunnel.

This tunnel seems to crawl forever but eventually begins to widen into a room with a wide room with a 6' tall roof. The floor is strewn with leaves, sticks, and the tracks of the giant ants. There are no other tracks in the room.

However, under the debris is a recently constructed, crude, large pit trap filled with punji sticks. Roll 1d12 to see how many spikes will strike a PC falling into the pit. Damage done is 1d4 per spike. At the other end of the passage, the various sticks upon the floor have been bespelled by *sticks to snakes* that will turn into six serpents that will attack the adventurers. Damage done is 1-3 plus save versus poison or death. A successful *dispel magic* cast into the room will either remove the loitering spell or the snakes.

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12. Skeletons in the Grass.

Entering this medium-sized room, the characters notice that the walls are lined with thick tree roots. Hanging in these roots is numerous old human and demi-human skeletons. There are 12 fresh corpses hanging in the roots. These are two gnolls, two goblins, six orcs, and two goblins. In the center of the room is a deep depression that has a small pile of treasure piled in the center.

Disturbing the treasure will alert the warrior skeletons that will immediately attack the offending adventurer.

Skeleton, Warrior (8): INT 15; AL NE; AC 2; MV 6; HD 9+2; hp 90; THACO 11; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4+4; MR 90%; SZ M; ML 15.

Treasure from the pit is 200 cp; 30 sp; 400 gp in miscellaneous gems.

13. Orcs in Waiting.

The smell of smoke drifts from this room. Grouped around several large campfires are a large number of orcs. There are three exits from this room, one to the North, one to the Northwest, and one to the Southwest.

Orcs (40): INT 9; AL LE; AC 6; MV 9; HD 1; hp 8; THACO 19; #AT 1; Dmg 1d8; SZ M; ML 12.

Orcs, Guards (10): INT 9; AL LE; AC 6; MV 9; HD 1+3; hp 5, 7, 8 (x3), 9 (x3), 11 (x2); THACO 19; #AT 1; Dmg 1d8+1; SZ M; ML 12.

Orc Shaman: INT 9; AL LE; AC 3; MV 9; HD 6; hp 48; THACO 15; #AT 1; Dmg 1d8; SA Spells: *cause blindness*, *cause serious wounds*, *cloud kill*, *blade barrier* (x2), *flame strike* (x2), *dispel magic* (x2), *burning hands*, *spiritual hammer*; scale mail, morning star, *breadbox augury*⁷; SZ M; ML 12.

Orc Sub-Chief: INT 11; AL LE; AC 2; MV 9; HD 8; hp 64; THACO 12; #AT 1; Dmg 1d8+3 (plus an additional 1d4 for first three attacks unless a save versus poison is made; *brigandine* +3, *broadsword* +2 (poisoned with type A blade poison); *potion of extra healing*, two phials of type A blade poison.

The orcs are part of Tantra Hagra's troops waiting here for her to return. They will try to send a few of the orcs ahead to warn her if possible and will be willing to discuss parley with the adventurers if over half of the orcs are slain. The treasure is 3 gp, 10 one-foot-long iron spindles bearing the seal of some city (Mirabar iron trade bars⁸, worth 10 gp in Mirabar but only 5-7 gp elsewhere), 40 sp, 30 cp, and 5 various cut gems worth 50 gp total.

13A. More Ants Again.

This long winding passage that seems to meander forever. Inside this passage is a medium-sized earthen mound that giant black ants are crawling all over. Should the adventurers enter this room, the ants will attack them.

Giant ants, Worker (30): INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 3; hp 24; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; MR nil; SZ S; ML 9.

Giant Ants, Warrior (30) INT 3; AL N; AC 3; MV 18; HD 5; hp 40; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; SA able to *phase*, sting for 3d4 (a successful save versus poison reduces the damage to 1d4); MR nil; SZ M; ML 12.

13B. More Gnolls.

This wide passage is lined with old tree roots, some of which bear carvings into the wood of bears, owls, snakes, large dogs, and eagles. Just entering the room by the opposite entrance is a large group of gnolls. The gnolls are led by three slightly shorter but stockier gnolls with darker fur carrying segmented iron bars with a length of chain between the segments. These darker gnolls are wearing armor and their weapons look in good repair, unlike the usual gnoll.

The gnolls have not noticed the adventurers yet unless they are using light or making noise.

Gnolls (25): INT 5; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 2; hp 16; THACO 19; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; SZ L; ML 11; 4 javelins each, medium shield, sword.

Flind Sub-lieutenants (2): INT 9; AL CE; AC 3; MV 12; HD 2+3; hp 22; THACO 17; #AT 2;

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Dmg 1d4; SA disarm (save versus wands or have weapon entangled and ripped from grasp); ring mail, bastard sword, flint bar; SZ L; ML 11.

Flint Lieutenant: INT 11; AL CE; AC 0; MV 12; HD 4; hp 32; THACO 13; #AT 2; Dmg 1d8+2; SZ L; ML 11; bronze plate mail, long sword, +2 flint bar.

14. Burial Chamber.

Five smoldering torches shoved into the earthen walls light this large chamber. The room is 55' wide and contains several large casket sized boxes. Most of the caskets are partially buried. Chattering excitedly on top of several of the caskets are several goblins. They are trying to pry open several of the boxes. Running around the goblins is six worgs. When the adventurers enter the room, the worgs immediately warn the goblins, which try to mount their worgs and attack the adventurers.

Goblins (12): INT 5; AL LE; AC 6; MV 6; HD 1-1; hp 3; THACO 20; #AT 1; Dmg 1d6; MR nil; SZ S; ML 10.

Worgs (6): INT 5; AL NE; AC 6; MV 18; HD 3+3; hp 33; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2d4; MR nil; SZ M; ML 11.

All of the caskets contain the remains of a warrior. One of the caskets contains the remains of an especially large fighter with a large 6' long, white oak shafted; obsidian tipped spear with an 18" blade. Just below the blade is a tuft of fur and three white eagle feathers. The spear is a +2, +3 *versus chaotic evil creatures*, +4 *versus extraplanar creatures*⁹. The spear is sacred to the Tree Ghost tribe as is the remains of the buried warriors. Searching all of the boxes will uncover 900 gp in various gems, 300 sp in small, uncut red rubies, and 20 white star sapphires cut into star clusters (worth 100 gp each).

14A. Large Cavern.

This large, wide cavern gently slopes down. Sitting in the damp earth near the opposite side of the room is a group of orcs. They are facing away from the adventurers and seem to be expecting something from the other passage.

Orcs (30): INT 9; AL LE; AC 6; MV 9; HD 1; hp 8; THACO 19; #AT 1; Dmg 1d8; SZ M; ML 12; medium shield, sword, 6 javelins.

The orcs carry only 3 gp, 2 sp, two gold rings (both contain mostly brass and are only worth 30 gp each), and one silver braid necklace (worth 100 gp).

14B. Trolls and Orcs.

This long narrow passage appears to have been water eroded. In the distance, the faint sounds of water can be heard dripping. The floor of this passage is very muddy and shows large, clawed tracks (troll) dragging something about human sized, wearing standard adventurer-type items.

In the center of this passage is a grisly sight. There are six trolls tearing apart what is left of three orcs. As the adventurers enter, the rear two trolls raise their heads and leap to attack.

Trolls (6): INT 6; AL CE; AC 4; MV 12; HD 6+6; hp 54; THACO 13; #AT 3; Dmg 2d4+1/2d4+1/3d4; SD regeneration; MR nil; SZ L; ML 14.

The dead orcs have 6 gp, 2 sp, one weeks worth iron rations, three unused torches, three flasks of lamp oil, and a small leather pouch. The pouch contains several small, parchment-wrapped packets of dried herbs (wolfsbane, garlic, pipeweed, and belladonna).

15. Passage to Room with Water.

The damp passage towards this room is littered with numerous tracks that make identification impossible. The passage ends in a large cavern that is dominated by a large pool of fresh water that has a large boulder in the center. The path continues around the perimeter of the pool and exits the room on the other side. On the rock is a gleaming spot of white that catches your eye.

Standing with their backs to the adventurers is a large group of 14 bugbears that are cheering a smaller bunch of 10 bugbears roped together that are wading in the water towards the boulder. A few of the bugbears are trying to climb the rock which to be too slick.

Bugbears (14): INT 6; AL CE; AC 4; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 27; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 1d10+2;